

AND THEN THE DRAGONS CAME: PUREWATER

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE

Purewater is built on water and admits it.

There is no ground. There are buildings, and there is water, and between them there are ledges a yard wide with no rail. The traffic that matters goes underneath, poled and rowed and shouting. The city drinks from a channel that runs down out of the lake and through the temple on Temple Isle, and the priestesses of the Lake Lady say the water is the goddess and mean it plainly.

Once there were Dragon Kings. They are gone and every child knows it. What is left of them is armour on the border lords, a name on a barony, and men who would like the old power back badly enough to pay for it.

The Lake Lady's Tourney comes once a year. Archery, single combat, and a scramble through the canals. It is older than the Governor's office. For three days the city fills with strangers and nobody looks closely at anybody.

This is what happened in those three days.

CHAPTER 1 — THE FORD



The mist did not lift. It was the same temperature as the air and it stood waist-high over the river and the queue stood in it.

Magda had walked three hundred miles. She had a quarterstaff and a staff sling and a purse with very little in it, and she was seventy years old and did not look it, which was the goddess's doing and not hers.

For eleven nights she had dreamed the same three things. A young woman with a wolf. A burning house. A knight in dragon-scale who was dead and had not been told. Hel did not explain. Hel pointed.

The woman from the dream was thirty feet up the queue.

She was younger than Magda had thought. Her cloak had been mended by someone with no gift for it. She was not looking at the city like the others. She was looking north up the road where the last of the dragon-scale was going away at a trot, and there was a grey wolf sitting against her leg, and nobody in the queue stood within eight feet of her.

Magda went up the outside of the line on the wolf's side, which is the wrong side.

At twelve feet the wolf stood up. It did not growl. A carter behind her said *oh* very quietly and found something to do with his hands.

She put her hand into the fur at the base of its neck where the ruff is thickest and a hand goes in to the wrist. The animal locked. Its

head came round and its jaw was four inches from her forearm and its breath was hot on the inside of her wrist.

She scratched. Down, once, the way you work out a burr.

The animal came apart in the shoulders first and then the back.

“—*don't*,” the woman said. She was three seconds too late and her hand had stopped halfway out of her cloak.

Magda kept scratching. She nodded once, the way you nod at a neighbour over a fence, and looked the woman in the eye.

“Who are you?”

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“Gardwen.”

“Magda.”

“You’ll want to be somewhere else, mother. People who stand near me have a poor time of it.”

“I’ve been dreaming of you, girl.”

The queue moved six feet and stopped. Neither of them moved with it.

“Your goddess,” Gardwen said. “Which one.”

“Hel. Death.” Magda watched her take it. “Not death in battle. The other kind. Everywhere else. In the bed, in the byre, in the bad winter. The ones nobody sings about.”

Gardwen looked at the mud for a while.

“That’s an honest god.”

The wolf sat down against Magda’s leg and not against hers, and she noticed that too.

“Does she show you a boy?”

“No. Not a boy.” Magda turned her free hand over, looking for the words. “A knight. Dragon-scale. Never seen anyone look that way

before and I've seen a great many people look a great many ways. He's dead, girl. Standing up and walking and dead, and nobody's told him."

"Dragon Knights." Gardwen's voice had gone flat. "It's Dragon Knights you dream of."

She did not say the rest.

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Magda knelt.

The mud took her knee with a sound like a boot coming out of a bog and it went straight through the wool. Somewhere behind her one of the tumblers said something and another one laughed and was hit.

She held the staff out crosswise in both hands, the way her grandmother had done it to a man who died the following spring.

"I'm to fight for you, girl. Protect you and yours, however you'd ask it. Die for you, if it comes to that."

Gardwen did not take the staff.

She got a hand under Magda's arm and hauled, and her grip was stronger than it looked and not steady at all.

"Get up. The ground's freezing, you'll ruin your knees, get up—"

She got her upright and did not let go straight away.

"Ten years," she said, very low. "Ten years and not one person. Not one. And a pig-farmer kneels in the *mud* at a *ford*—"

She stopped. She put her face back on and it did not sit right.

"I don't know what to do with you."

Then she offered her forearm, wrist to wrist, the woodland way.

"My brother was taken by men in that armour. Ten years ago. He's the only thing I have left to look for, and I'm three days behind that column, and if your god has business with a dead man in dragon-scale then Hel and I want the same road for a while."

Magda took the arm.

Behind them the ford had opened and the queue had started to move properly, and the crowd went round the two of them like water round a stone.

CHAPTER 2 — NO GROUND



They came into the city at midday and did not see the column arrive.

The column came through the water-gate into Caravan Square at the same hour: twenty-odd Dragon Knights, banners cased, and a covered litter in the middle with the curtains laced shut and the escort facing inward as much as out. The Baron rode uncovered and let the city look at him. A knight at his stirrup got a clear look at a thief's face in the crowd and went white to the lips, and said nothing, and by evening the whole quarter was talking about a litter that had to be watched.

Magda and Gardwen were two miles out on the causeway and heard none of it.

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The water-gate had a chain-boom and a customs man in Harbor Masters' green with ink on his fingers and a tally-board under his arm. He had turned two people back that morning.

Magda went up the line past the fishmonger and the family with the goat and stood at his elbow with the wolf at her knee.

He turned with his mouth already open.

She looked at him.

She had buried people. Not in wars. In beds. She had put her hand over the eyes of men who had been shouting an hour before and then gone out and fed the pigs, because the pigs do not care. She let him have all of it.

“We’re going in.”

He looked at the staff, which had never once pretended to be a walking stick. He looked at the wet grey animal. He looked back at her face and did not find anything there that was negotiating.

“There’s a fee,” he said. There was no starch in it.

“There is.”

She did not fill the silence. He filled it himself by looking down at his tally-board, which was a good board and had a lot of him in it.

“Two on foot,” he said to it. “And a *dog*.” He wrote *dog*. He underlined it. “Muzzled inside the Merchant’s Quarter, that’s not me, that’s the Guild, and if it goes for anyone it’s your neck not mine—”

“Understood.”

“—and I never saw it.”

“You never did.”

He stepped aside, small, so it would not look like stepping aside. As she passed under the boom he said, to nobody:

“Everyone’s mad this week. It’s the Tourney.” Then, because he could not help it: “Third lot today gone through with something they won’t show me.”

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Gardwen stopped six feet inside the gate with her back to a wall.

The noise came up off the water and off the stone at once and hit from underneath. The smell was salt and tar and hot oil and under it the sweetish note of a city sitting in its own water.

“There’s no *ground*,” she said.

“Yeah. It’s all boats and barges and slipways here, lass.” Magda took her arm. “Let’s get to the Pearl.”

She learned it the way woodland people learn things, badly for ten minutes and then all at once. By the third bridge she had stopped looking at her feet. By the fifth she was reading the water — which boat had right of way, which shout meant *move*. The wolf hated all of it and did it anyway, low and close and wet.

Away to the left, over the roofs, a bell started. Then another, ragged, out of time with the first.

They stopped before anyone could ask what they were for.

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The Pearl was an island and the loudest quiet place in the city: swept steps, lamps lit at three in the afternoon, music from an upper window, two women on a balcony watching the street the way farmers watch weather.

The green door had a sylph carved on the lintel, worn smooth by two hundred years of hands.

Magda knocked the way she had knocked twenty years before.

The woman who opened it was older than the knock remembered. Grey coming in at the temple, an apron over good clothes, flour to the wrists.

“*Magda.*”

“Constantine.”

“You’re not dead.” She said it with real pleasure, one professional to another.

She took in the rest of it in one pass — the young woman standing too straight, the staff, the wolf — and only one eyebrow moved.

“Beds. It’s Tourney week, I’ve got the city and half the border in my lap and every room’s spoken for—” She held the door wide. “So you’ll

have the top back room over the water, and it's cold, and the shutter sticks. Bring the dog. If it eats a client I'll take it out of your purse."

A girl of thirteen went past the foot of the stairs with an armful of linen twice her size, saw the wolf, and dropped all of it.

"*Ila*," Constantine said, without heat.

She was not listening.

On the landing above, leaning on the rail with her hair down, an elven woman with a cup in one hand looked down the stairwell and laughed.

"Constantine. You've brought home a wolf."

"I've brought home a friend, Emmeralda. The wolf is incidental."

CHAPTER 3 — THE SHRIEKS OF THE SYLPH



The young man came at dusk and knocked three times, confident.

Magda went down as far as the turn of the stair and looked over the rail. The fourth step from the top had a voice and she had forgotten it, and it spoke under her, but she got her look first.

Twenty-two or three. Dark clothes cut border-fashion with the road-dust still on the hem. Handsome in the way that gets told to a boy early. He was too bright. There was sweat at his hairline in a cold stone hall and he laughed a half-beat before the joke finished, twice.

His cloak hung badly on the left. Something under it at the hip. Not a sword — the hang was wrong, too short and too far forward. Something with a guard on it.

His right hand went to that place four times while she watched, and each time it came away, and he did not know he was doing it.

Beside her the wolf's hackles came up along her whole spine.

Then the step creaked and he looked up, fast, before the smile was back — and for a quarter of a second what was on his face was not fear of being caught. It was fury. The flat outraged fury of something interrupted.

Then the smile arrived.

“Ah — forgive me,” he said, and bowed, and it was a real bow. “I didn’t know the house had guests up. I’ve been rude.”

“My old friend from the north, my lord,” Constantine said. “Deaf as a post and twice as stubborn.”

“I would never.” He held it two beats longer than a man looking at furniture.

Then he turned back and his hand went to his hip a fifth time.

“Now. Emmeralda. She’s expecting me — I’ve paid for the whole evening, and I’d take it very kindly if we weren’t disturbed.”

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Magda went back up.

“Young lord downstairs,” she said. “Paid for the evening. It’s a bawdy-house, lass. That’s the trade.”

“You don’t like him.”

“I don’t like anybody.”

Gardwen took the floor by the brazier and was asleep in ninety seconds. Magda lay on the bed with her boots off and her staff under her hand and looked at the ceiling and thought about a hang that was wrong for a sword.

The music stopped downstairs. The house went quiet by degrees. She went under.

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She came up because the wolf was standing.

Ruhi was at the door with her ears flat and every hair up and she had made no sound at all. That was what had woken her. Not noise. The absence of it.

Then it came. It was higher than a scream and had no shape and went on past the length of one breath.

Then it stopped, mid-note.

And in the ringing after it a young man's well-bred border voice was saying something fast and low and rhythmic that did not stop when the screaming did.

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Afterwards nobody could say how long it was.

There was a crash below — a chest going over, and glass — and a man's voice saying *no no no no* very fast, and a door hitting a wall hard enough to shake the frame two floors up. Running on the canal-side stair. A slip. A body hitting a landing full length and something metal skittering away across boards.

A shutter thrown. A splash in the canal far too big for a man getting neatly into a boat.

Then voices all over the house.

And from the room they had gone into, nothing.

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Magda went down. Ila caught her on the second landing with two fistfuls of her skirt and a face white to the lips, saying *she won't open it*, and Gardwen went past both of them without breaking stride.

Magda went down instead of up.

The water door stood half open, swinging. She loaded as she went — stone in the pouch, cord round the knuckles, staff cocked back along her forearm.

The slipway was four steps into black water. A skiff rode hard on its painter. The water off the steps was still turning over, slow and deep, the way water does when something has gone into it heavy.

Something pale was on the second step at the waterline. She hauled it up. A cloak, sodden, good cloth, road-dust under the wet.

Thirty feet out and moving upstream there was a wake — the ugly chop of a man swimming badly and in a hurry. She got a head, and

the pale smear of a face turning back toward the house, and then the shoulders working.

He was making for the iron rungs under the far lamp. He had covered a third of it. He had not seen her.

The range was nothing.

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She did not hear it hit. She saw it. The head snapped sideways, hard, wrong, the way a head goes when it has stopped being steered from inside.

He went under without a sound. There was one hand above the surface for a moment, open, not grasping at anything.

Then that was gone too.

The chop smoothed out. The lamp on the far bank went on being a lamp.

Upstairs a woman began to scream and did not stop, and it was not Emmeralda's voice.

CHAPTER 4 — THE SCULLERY



The demon sat up in the bed and asked for its shawl.

Emmeralda was opened from the hollow of her throat to her hip. One cut, drawn slow with something barbed, and the edges were wrong and it was still bleeding and nothing was holding it closed. The chalk figure on the boards had a scuff through it at the foot where a man had stepped backwards out of it in a hurry.

She had her head tilted and she was smiling at the door.

“You needn’t crowd,” she said. “It doesn’t hurt at all.”

Gardwen had closed it with both hands and everything she had. The flesh had knit. Then it had opened again from the inside, deliberately, like a hand pulling back a curtain.

“I think it *liked* it,” she said afterwards in the passage. “I think it wanted to see what I’d do.”

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Magda went in and sat on the coverlet where the thing patted it.

“You feel ok, lass? What’s all this though?”

It looked down at the wound the way you look at a stain on a good tablecloth, and touched the edge with two fingers, and the flesh moved under them.

“That’s the way in. He wasn’t very neat about it, but he got there in the end, bless him — he was so nervous, Magda. Shaking. I had to be kind to him.”

The fingers came away red. It did not notice.

“He’s coming back, you know. He said so. He was very definite about it.” It plucked at the coverlet, tidying. “So we should have the room straight. And someone really ought to sweep up that chalk.”

“Who is the young gentleman? So we know how tae greet him. On his return.”

“Santo. Just Santo — he didn’t give me the rest, they never do, they think it’s clever.” A confiding lean, and the wound gaped with it. “He said he’d come back for the others. Four more, he said, and then his father would *have* to see. He was quite emotional about it.”

Behind her Constantine had both hands flat on the doorframe and had gone the colour of tallow.

“*Santo*,” she said. “He said *Santo*.”

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The ring was sewn into the lining of the cloak. Heavy gold, a man’s, with a beast cut into the face: long, coiled round on itself, the tail through its own jaws.

“That’s their arms,” Constantine said, and did not touch it. “The worm eating itself. It’s on the litter, it’s on the banners, it’s on every second cup in this city this week.”

There were eleven border coins, unchanged since he arrived. A tailor’s mark stitched inside the collar where the wearer never looks — a little tower with three windows, embroidered rather than stamped. A letter gone to pulp in the canal, dried against a lamp glass until two things survived: —*ee days before the Lady’s Tourney, at the hou—*, and the bottom half of a seal with the same beast on it.

And five twists of oiled silk. Four of them full. Each held a hank of long dark red hair bound at one end with fine copper wire.

Emmeralda's hair was black to the root.

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Constantine's counting room, with the door shut.

"Santo di Teufel is the son and heir of Baron Hanzo di Teufel, who rode into this city this morning with twenty-odd Dragon Knights at his back, and who is at this moment the guest of half the men on the Governor's council."

She dragged a hand down her face.

"There is a dead di Teufel in the canal behind my house and a demon sitting up in my green room asking for her shawl, and there are nineteen people under this roof tonight."

"Twenty-two," Gardwen said from the corner. "There are three in the kitchen."

"Twenty-two." Constantine closed her eyes. "What do we do?"

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They needed the body and the body was under nine feet of black water with the ebb two hours off.

Gardwen went in on a line and came up thrashing eighteen inches from the gunwale, not swimming, climbing at the water like it was a wall, and put the skiff over on its beam ends. Magda got a fist in the line and the other in the back of her shirt and hauled her aft where the freeboard was lowest and brought her in over the transom like a netted fish. She lay in six inches of bilge and coughed up canal and could not speak for a while.

"That," she said eventually, "is not a river."

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So it was the girl.

Ila came down the slipway barefoot in her shift with somebody's shawl over it and her face blotched from crying and lit up with purpose, and was in the boat before anyone offered a hand.

"What am I looking for?"

Magda told her the truth, all of it, in about four sentences, and then said *Gardwen, fuck, help me explain, I'm no good at this.*

Gardwen came forward on her knees so she was down at the child's level.

"When I was your age, men came to my house at night and killed my family. Every one of them. And I hid, because I was small and there was nothing else I could do, and I have spent ten years being the person who hid." She put the line into Ila's hands. "Nobody's asking you to hide. There's a job, and you're the only one in this boat who can do it, and it's a *filthy* job. You'll touch him. It'll be over in a minute and you will not like any part of it, and then Emmeralda's house stays standing."

Ila's fingers closed on the line.

"Two tugs if I've got him. Three if I need to come up."

She went in without a splash. The line paid out smooth and long and stopped.

Ten. Twenty.

Two tugs. Firm. Then two more, and the line went dead-weight heavy.

She surfaced with her arms round it and her face at the sky.

"His face is *up*," she said.

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Afterwards Magda took the wet shawl off her and put her own cloak on her instead, which swamped her entirely and smelled of three weeks of road and pig, and rubbed her arms hard enough to hurt.

“You went into black water on the word of an old woman you met this morning, and you found what you were sent for, and you came back up and you said the right thing first. His face is up. That’s the whole job.”

“I touched his—”

“Aye. You did. That’ll come back on you tonight and probably tomorrow and then less after that.” She pulled the cloak closed under the girl’s chin and held it there. “It doesn’t mean anything’s wrong with you. It means you did a hard thing. There’s a difference, and nobody tells you, so I’m telling you.”

The girl folded forward against her and cried for about a minute with her fists in Magda’s shirt.

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The scullery had stone to waist height, a slate table, a drain in the corner and a shuttered window onto the canal. Constantine lit two lamps, set out the saw and the cleaver and the bone-tub, said *I’ll be in the counting room*, and went.

She did not come back.

They worked. It was not fast and it was not hard. You find the joint and you go through the joint and you do not fight the bone. Gardwen held what needed holding and turned what needed turning and did not flinch once.

The drain did its work. The canal took the rest.

“We killed one of the enemy tonight, girl. That’s a good start.”

Gardwen stopped with her hands on the table.

“He’s the right age to be one of their sons. Not one of the men.” She turned a piece over. “Ten years ago he’d have been twelve. Sat at somebody’s table while it happened. But he grew up into exactly what they wanted him to grow into, and he did *that* to Emmeralda with four more women’s hair in his cloak, and I’d have put the stone through his head myself.”

She wiped her wrist across her forehead and left a mark there she did not know about.

“It’s a start. It’s not the one I came for.”

Four barrels. Constantine’s own, with her own house-mark burned in the ends.

She walked them down to the hog-yard herself at the fifth bell, because it was not the sort of thing you send a boy with.

CHAPTER 5 — WHAT THE LAUNDRESS SAW



The ship steamed where it sat.

It lay at a private pier on the seaward side of High Isle, black-hulled and dragon-prowed and moored bow-in so it could leave at any hour without turning. Where the hull met the water the water boiled, in a continuous white sheet a hundred feet long, and there was no fire under it. Gulls would not go near. There was a dead-water slick round the stern with things in it floating belly-up.

Magda stood in the lee of a cooorage for the better part of an hour and watched what a ship actually needs.

Almost nothing went aboard. That was the first thing. No chandler's boy, no water butts. Everything came up under a covered gangway with the canvas laced down, in the crews' own hands, from their own boat.

Things came off. Slops, twice, carried down in a covered pail by a knight and tipped into the dead water where nobody was collecting it. Barrows of ash and clinker, far more than a galley fire makes. And one bag of laundry, handed down at the bollards to a woman with a barrow who was not allowed past.

Nobody who was not a Dragon Knight went past the bollards all afternoon.

She counted the men. Eight. Two at the pier head, two at the ramp, three working on deck, one going up and down with the clinker. No banner at the masthead. No household, no clerk, no valet, no Baron.

Amidships, well above the waterline, one shuttered port. Closed on a hot bright day, and barred from the outside.

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The hog-man's lad was called Pell and could not back a nag.

Magda went to the horse's head, and the horse laid its ears flat and swung its quarters and put the offside wheel into the spoil heap, and a barrel went over. They spent two minutes getting the wheel out and by the end they were both filthy and he had stopped being embarrassed.

"She does that. Every time. Right at the end."

"She's testing whether you've noticed her. Go to her head *before* she starts, not after."

He considered this with the deep suspicion of a fifteen-year-old being told something obviously true.

He did the Forge Quarter yards on alternate days for a man called Renko out on the Shoals, which Magda kept her face still about. He complained at length about the rope-walk, who had put nails in their waste. Then he jerked his chin down the pier at the steaming hull.

"Not that lot, though. *They* don't give us nothing."

"Tight bunch, are they?"

"They're *unnatural*, is what they are." He hauled the rope down with his whole weight. "Every yard on this side gives us their waste. That's how it works. That lot tip it in the water. In the *water*. Good scraps, meat and all. Renko went down there himself first day and offered to take it for nothing, and they walked him back up the pier by his elbows.

"Only one that gets anything off them is the laundry woman. Yannick's wife. Bag down at the bollards, coin in her hand, off you go. She's not allowed past neither." He shrugged. "She won't talk about it,

though. Went right off, she has. Which is a shame, 'cause she'll talk about anything."

Magda asked how big the bag was.

He stopped and thought about it, which he clearly had not done before.

"Not big. One bag. She could carry it on her hip." He frowned. "Every day, though. That's the thing. Rope-walk's forty men and they send out twice a week. That ship sends out every day and it's one bag. And it's all the same, she said once. Not shirts and hose like a normal house. All the one thing."

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The wash-house was behind the rope-walk. Three coppers on the boil, lines of other people's linen the length of it, and the heat enormous.

Ann Yannick was alone in there with a wooden paddle.

Magda came in out of the sun, took the bench by the door where the draught was, and sat down the way a woman of seventy sits down. Then she did not say anything. She looked at her boots. She rubbed her knee. She said, once, to nobody, that the steam was pleasant on the joints.

The paddle went on. Copper, lift, turn.

It took a long while.

"Do you know what boiled blood smells like?"

Magda said nothing.

"Course you do. You've a face like you've buried people." She went on paddling. "Four days I've had that. Every morning. One bag, and it's all sheets, and every one of them's the same."

Copper. Lift. Turn.

"It's not a wound. I've done a house with a consumptive in it. I've done a birth-bed. I've done a man who lost a hand at the rope-walk. You get a shape to it — where it came from, how it lay, whether he

thrashed.” She looked up. “This is the same shape every day. Same place on the sheet. Same size. Like it’s been let out of him careful, in the same spot, and mopped, and put back.”

She jerked her chin at the end copper, on its own with the lid half over it.

“And there’s something else in it that doesn’t come out. Not blood. Blood boils out with lye and time. That goes *grey*, and it smells like the forge, and my hands were numb to the elbow the first day and I’ve worn gloves since.”

She set the paddle down.

“They pay double. My man says take it. And I lie there at night thinking — whoever’s in that ship, he’s still bleeding tomorrow. Four days. Somebody’s keeping him alive to do it again.”

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Magda tried sympathy and it did not work. Her face did not know how to be that, and the joke she made about blood was the sort that is funny in a byre at four in the morning and is not funny in a wash-house.

Ann Yannick’s face closed like a door.

“You’re not from the yards.”

So Magda told her the truth instead.

“No. Not from here. I’m from the north, where the winds are cold and the ice is sharp. I joke about blood because I’ve cleaned up my fair share. And I’m interested because the men on that boat are up to some evil shit that might need stopping.”

The woman looked at her a long moment through the steam. Whatever she was checking for, she did not find it.

“North,” she said. “Aye. I thought there was something in the vowels.”

She worked for a bit.

“Three things, then. And I’ll deny every one of them if you ever say I said it.

“One. It’s not a sick lad. Sick men sweat, and they piss the bed, and they stink of the sickness. There’s none of that. There’s blood in the same place every day and nothing else. Whoever’s in that bed isn’t ill and isn’t dying and isn’t getting better. He’s being kept.

“Two. Second morning the bag came heavier and there was a shirt in it. Not linen — a fighting man’s quilted under-shirt, for wearing under scale. The arming-points were cut. Not untied. *Cut*, front and back, the way you do when you’re getting something off a man who isn’t helping you.

“Three.” She stopped paddling. “The knight who hands the bag down. Big fellow, white eyebrows, no colour in him at all. Yesterday he asks me, all friendly, whether I ever wash for the houses on the Pearl.”

She looked straight at Magda.

“I said no. But he wasn’t asking about laundry, was he.”

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Magda asked one more thing: which part of the boy they were bleeding.

Ann Yannick took a clean sheet off the stack and shook it out flat across the bench and put her hand down on it.

“Sheet goes on the bed this way — hem to the head, you can tell from the wear where a man’s heels go. So. It’s *here*.” High, a little left of the middle. “Every morning, four days. About the size of my two hands together. Upper body. Left side. Chest, or just under the arm.”

She folded it back up.

“Somebody opens the same place, the same way, every morning. And then somebody else changes the bed.”

She squared the stack off and stood there with both hands on it.

“You said choose sides.”

She went to the end copper and lifted the lid and started fishing the load out into a basket.

“They’re due at the sixth bell for that. They’ll get it. I’ll smile at the white-haired bastard and take his coin. But you tell Marisette that Ann Yannick washes for that ship every morning, and she’ll go on doing it, and she’ll go on *looking*.”

Her jaw set.

“And if that boy’s still bleeding on the day of the Tourney, I want somebody to have done something about it.”

CHAPTER 6 — TWO POWERS



Marisette did accounts by lamplight at four in the morning and had been up since the third bell.

Her counting room was small and warm and lined with ledgers and smelled of coffee. She wore a plain grey wrap and no jewellery and looked like a woman who had been doing sums for two hours and would rather still be doing them.

She poured three cups without asking whether anyone wanted them.

“Before you start. At about the third bell there was noise at your house, Constantine. A woman screaming, and then not screaming, which is worse. My man on the bridge saw your water door open and your skiff out twice — once with three people in it and once with four, and one of the four was Ila, and she went in the water, and she came out of it crying.” Her hands were folded. “He came and told me because he knows I like Ila.

“You’ve got twenty minutes before I have to be someone else. Tell me what’s in my island.”

Magda told her. It took about six sentences and she left nothing out, including the pigs.

Marisette did not move at all while she talked. At the end she turned one of the coffee cups a quarter-turn on its saucer, and that was all that happened for five seconds.

“Say the last part again.”

“Hanzo di Teufel’s son.”

“Santo.” Flat, like checking a number. “He came to my house three days ago asking after Asphodel and I turned him away because I didn’t like his hands.” She was completely still. “I sent him to *Constantine’s*.”

Constantine said her name.

“Don’t.”

*
**

She went through the cloak’s contents like a woman counting stock. The ring she barely glanced at. The letter she read twice. Then she came to the oiled silk, and opened the first twist with her thumbnail, and the copper wire and the long dark red hairs came out into the lamplight.

She stopped.

“Constantine. Who at your house has red hair?”

“Nobody.”

“No. Nobody at mine either.” She laid the hairs flat on the desk and separated them with one fingernail, precisely, the way you lay out evidence. “There are two women on this island with hair that colour, and I know them both, and neither of them works. One of them is a Watercrafter’s daughter. The other is the High Priestess of the Lake Lady’s own niece.”

*
**

Then Magda nodded at Gardwen, and Gardwen told hers.

She told it the way you give a report, with no shape to it, which is the worst way to hear it. Nine of them at the steading. She was

eleven. They fired the house and killed everyone in it and she lived because she was small and the woods took her. In the morning she went back and counted them, and counted them all, and her brother was not there. He was seven. They had taken him alive and taken only him out of nine people and burned the rest so nobody would count.

“That boy in the canal said his father would *have to see*. That means his father makes things too. And his father has had my brother for ten years.”

Nobody said anything.

Marisette sat back.

“A litter,” she said slowly. “Curtains sewn shut. Guards facing inward.”

“Aye.”

“He entered a champion for the Single Combat. Nobody has seen the man. It’s been the joke of the week.” Her fingers had gone still. “How old would your brother be now?”

“Seventeen.”

“Then it isn’t him. Santo was twenty-two.” She let it sit exactly long enough. “But a champion nobody has seen is not a champion. It’s a *thing being kept*. Men who are proud of a swordsman show him off. You don’t face inward to keep people out. You face inward to keep something in.”

She stood.

“Which makes it my island’s business, and I don’t have twenty minutes any more.”

*
**

Temple Isle after dark was a different city. The canals ran quiet and the water in them was clear — you could see the bottom by lamplight, which you could not do anywhere else in Purewater.

The temple sat low and wide with its foundations in the water, all open colonnades and no doors, and the whole building was full of the sound of water moving through it on purpose.

The High Priestess was sitting on the step of the great tank with her feet in the channel and her sleeves pushed up, doing nothing at all.

“Leave the wolf,” she said. “It can drink. Nothing in this water will mind.”

Then, with no ceremony left in it: “Marisette does not send people to me. Ever. So say the worst of it first and we’ll work backwards.”

“That’d be when I killed Hanzo’s evil little shit of a son after he bound a demon into one of the girls at the Sylph’s Embrace. And then fed his body to pigs.”

Nerissa looked at her for a while.

“You smiled,” she said, “when you said *pigs*.”

“Aye.”

“Mm.” She took her feet out of the tank and dried them on the hem of her robe like a farmer’s wife. “Good. I’d not trust a person who could say that flatly.”

*
**

She traded.

“Yesterday, four minutes after noon, this channel went *wrong*. Not fouled — I’ve had fouled, fouled is a dead ox and a week of prayers. This went thin. The Lady’s presence in her own water went thin, the way a voice goes thin at a distance, in the space of about ten heartbeats. I have served here since I was nineteen and it has never once done that.

“So I rang the tower. And by the third peal there was a boy from the Governor’s household at my gate with a written instruction to cease, on the grounds that the city was welcoming a distinguished guest.”

“And you stopped.”

"I stopped." Something flat and furious went across her face. "Because I had nothing. A thin feeling in the water and no cause I could name in front of a magistrate. If I had rung on I would have been removed by Thursday and replaced by somebody who wouldn't ring at all."

She came and sat closer.

"Say the part about my niece again. Slowly."

*
**

Magda laid it out on the low table by the lamp the way you show someone a bad joint of meat. The cloak. The tailor's tower. The ring. The letter dried against a lamp glass. Eleven border coins.

Then the oiled silk. Five. Four still full.

"So he came into this city carrying five women in his coat," Nerissa said. "And he spent one of them on a girl at Constantine's, and he had four left."

She picked up the first twist and did not open it. Her thumb moved once across the silk.

Then: "Beneath the wire. Is there a knot in it, or is it cut clean at both ends?"

Magda turned it. The wire was at one end. The other was blunt and square, every strand the same length.

"Cut clean."

"Then it was taken with shears, off a head, by somebody standing behind her." Nerissa laid it down very carefully. "It was not gathered off a comb. Somebody got close enough to my sister's daughter to put shears in her hair, and she did not scream, and she has not told me."

She looked up.

"Her name is Sana. She's nineteen. She has been at the school on the Northern Isles for six weeks and I have not seen her in three."

CHAPTER 7 — LOST ISLE



They had sent a boat at dusk and it had never arrived.

The mistress of the school opened the door at one in the morning and had been crying. Sana had been gone since the previous morning. They had every girl out looking and they had dragged the channel.

And across four hundred yards of black water, on the drowned ruin the boatmen gave a wide berth, there was a light moving. Dull red, low, close to the waterline. It went in a straight line for a bit and stopped and after a while moved again.

Gardwen went down on one knee at the channel edge and put both hands flat in the water.

Nothing came. She sat back on her heels breathing like she had run there.

“Too far. It’s not the distance. The water’s all hers here and I’m not hers, and I was asking a favour in someone else’s house.”

Nerissa was already unpinning her sleeves.

“You reached. From the bank. Across running water that isn’t yours.” She stepped down into the channel to her knees and held out her hand. “So come inside and ask properly.”

The second time was not like the first.

Gardwen's fingers locked on hers hard enough to hurt and her breath went out of her all at once, and Nerissa stood in the water and took it the way you hold a rope.

"The whole island's humming. Underneath. Not evil, just old." Her eyes were shut. "Above that, on the stone, there's a working. Same hand as the chalk on her floor. It's not finished. It's laid out, like a table before dinner. And it's cold — whoever set it hasn't come back to it in a day."

"Living things."

"Two moving. Both of them wrong. Not demons — men, but wrong, the way milk's wrong." Her head turned, tracking. "They're low down and they're together and they've gone still since the light went out."

She stopped.

"There's a third. Not moving. Not wrong." Her voice cracked. "She's small in it. Gone right down small the way you do when you're hiding. She's above the other two. Up high, in the stone."

"Is she alive?"

"She's *frightened*," Gardwen said. "You can't be frightened if you're not alive."

*
**

Lost Isle was a street.

That was the thing. You could see the line of it — doorways and window-holes at chest height, a gutter, the stub of a wellhead — and all of it standing in four feet of black water with weed growing out of the windows. They waded up somebody's road with the water at their thighs. Nerissa touched a doorframe as she passed, briefly, the way you touch a coffin.

The tower-stub came up out of the weed eighty feet on. Three storeys, one corner gone, the bottom ten feet drowned.

Gardwen put a hand flat on the stone and called up it, pitched to carry no further.

“Sana. Your aunt sent me. She’s stood in the water at the corner and she’s got her mace and she is extremely angry.”

Nothing. Then, three floors up, small and hoarse:

“Say what she calls my mother.”

“I don’t know,” Magda said. “But I know you sent her an eleven page letter about a heron. The three line one raised an alarm, and that’s why we’re here.”

A long silence. Stone grit came down and landed in the water.

“I don’t— I don’t remember writing eleven pages.”

“You did. She’s told it twice tonight and she’s not a woman who repeats herself.”

She came down slowly, stopping twice to breathe, and Gardwen went up the half-stair and brought her the last of it. Nineteen years old, barefoot in a school shift, her hair chopped ragged on the left side of her head.

She gripped Gardwen’s forearm and would not let go.

“There were three of them yesterday. Only two since this morning — the other went off in the boat before dawn and hasn’t come back.” She was shaking. “They didn’t come for me. They came for the *place*. I only ran because I saw. They had a girl from the school with them and she was walking with them like she knew them.”

She looked between them.

“Bettan. She’s fourteen. She’s the one they sent to the temple last night with the message.”

*

**

They were sitting side by side on the edge of a slab in the dark, in a room with half a roof and no wall on the water side, and they turned their heads at the same moment. Not together like men who heard the same thing. At once, the same speed, like two doors on one hinge.

“You’re not her,” one said.

“—she was meant to bring the girl,” the other finished.

Neither stood up.

The sling took the sandy one high on the right arm and she heard the bone go from twenty feet. The arm dropped. He did not make a sound and did not look at it.

They stood up together, the same speed, as if the slab had tipped them.

“That’s going to make the poling difficult,” he said, with his arm hanging off him.

“We’ll manage.”

*
**

It went on longer than it should have.

Magda broke the sandy one’s arm at the elbow with the staff and he straightened up and inspected the ruin of it with interest, the way you’d look at a torn coat. Neither of them bled. Ruhi took the other under the water and he did not struggle for air because he did not need any, and got a hand into her ruff and worked it deeper while she thrashed.

Gardwen’s Hold Person took the sandy one mid-step and he froze with his weight forward and his eyes still moving.

“It shouldn’t hold,” she said, white. “Magda — that’s *Hold Person*. There shouldn’t be enough person in him to grip.”

The other one caught Magda’s forearm in the shallows and closed on it like a piece of machinery, no squeeze and no threat, just a closing to a fixed position and then no further movement at all. He called to nobody in particular that he had this one, and the frozen man said *good*, and Ruhi took his legs from under him and all three went under together.

He did not try to hold her down. He lay on the bottom of a drowned street holding on, waiting, because he did not need to breathe and had all night.

Gardwen put three words into the water and his hand opened, all four fingers at once, like a catch releasing.

He sat up in the water and looked at his own palms.

“That wasn’t me,” he said, with something like interest.

*
**

Afterwards Magda killed him with the staff while he was standing with his hands open, and Nerissa was four feet away and did not move for a moment.

“He had stopped,” she said. Not accusing. Reading a figure back to check she had it. “He had stopped, and he was showing me the stone.”

And what he had been showing her was not a slab.

It was the top of a stair. Four steps of cut stone going down at an angle into black water that did not hold the lamplight, with the weed hacked off the edges and the treads swept clean where there should have been a foot of silt.

“It’s a door,” Nerissa said, on her knees with both palms on the carving. “Not for people. For the drowned.”

Her fingers went under the surface and kept going.

“There are stories about the Northern Isles going under. A slow flood, over generations, and everything in them that died went down with the streets. And whoever cut this cut it so that what stayed in the water had somewhere to go. A way out.” She looked up. “You lay them to rest through a thing like this.”

Behind them, roped and sitting in the shallows, the sandy one said pleasantly:

“That’s what he went to fetch the boat for. You’d best hurry — he’s been gone since before dawn and he’ll not be coming back alone.”

CHAPTER 8 — THE NAME



His name was Ellick Sarn and he had to think about it.

“That’s — yes. That’s right, I’m fairly sure. I poled the Forge Quarter run. Timber mostly, sometimes charcoal, and a woman called Tam who I think was—”

He stopped and frowned at the sky.

“There was something about Tam. It’s gone.”

He sat trussed in the bottom of the boat, agreeable as a man taking a seat at an inn, and told them how it happened. The quiet one had paid him eleven marks to take him out to the drowned streets four times and say nothing. He had said nothing. He wanted that noted. He had kept his end.

“And then on the fourth time he said, would I like to not be cold any more.”

He said it perfectly evenly.

“I’ve been cold on that water for thirty-one years. Every winter. Hands gone the colour of the sky. And he said it like he was offering me a coat. And I said yes. That’s the part everyone wants to skip past. Nobody did anything to me that I didn’t stand still for.”

“What went in you?”

“Something out of the stairs.” A shrug that moved the whole trussed body oddly. “It’s not unkind. It doesn’t want anything much. It likes the digging. It’s got a lot more of me than it had at Candlemas. That’s the trade — it warms you and it wears you, and you don’t notice the wearing because the part that would notice is the part it’s wearing.”

Then, conversationally:

“You’ll be wanting to know about the one on the ship. That’s a different thing entirely. That one’s *furnished*.”

*
**

He told them that too.

“Mine’s content. It got a boatman who was cold and it’s warm now and it likes lifting stone. There’s no fight in it. That’s why I’m still able to sit here and talk to you about Tam and nearly remember her.

“That one *fight*s.

“I was aboard twice, carrying. You can hear it through the deck. Not screaming — worse than that, it’s *arguing*. Goes on for hours. Two voices out of one throat having a row, and one of them’s a boy and one of them isn’t, and the one that isn’t sounds like a man who’s been told to do something he thinks is dishonourable.”

He shook his head slowly.

“That’s what the morning cut’s for. It’s not just the wear. It’s to keep it tired. You bleed a man to keep him from arguing.”

He worked his jaw, hunting.

“They’ve a name for it. Old-sounding. Thoo— Thuban. Thuban something. Eta, maybe. He’s a knight out of the dragon wars and he’s been in one thing or another for a very long while, and he doesn’t want to be, and he never has.”

He looked round the boat at all of them.

“You keep saying rescue the boy. I’d think about that. There’s two in there, and only one of them’s been asking to get out.”

*
**

Thorne kept the corner of the Moist Oyster and a stub of chalk he turned over in his fingers.

At the name he put the chalk down.

“Say that again.”

“Thuban Eta.”

“Thuban Eta was real. That’s not a story name. That’s a *muster roll* name.”

He had been Order of the Lake for thirty-one years before he wasn’t.

“The Dragon Kings had knight-companies and the Eta were one of them — the letter’s a company mark, not a family. And Thuban was the one they teach you about in your second year, because of how he died.

“He wouldn’t burn a town.

“That’s the whole of it. The company was ordered to fire a valley and he refused and argued it in front of the others, and about a third of them came round to him. So the ones who hadn’t took him out on the water at night to talk it over, and they put him over the side in his mail with his hands tied.

“Drowned. By his own company. For refusing an order that even they thought was filthy — that’s the part that damns them. They knew he was right and they killed him for making them know it.”

He looked up.

“And that is exactly the kind of dead man you can bind. You don’t hold a shade with iron, mother. You hold it with the thing it can’t put down. You keep him in the moment of it — tied hands and cold water and his own men’s faces looking down at him. He’ll pull against it for a hundred years and never once get out, and every time he pulls you can use the pulling.”

“That’s what’s in my brother,” Gardwen said.

“That’s what’s in your brother. And it has been for ten years, and it has hated every hour, because a man who wouldn’t fire a valley is not going to enjoy being made into a champion.”

He pushed the chalk away.

“Your goddess said *lay him to rest*. Everyone at this table has been thinking that means a door and a ritual. It might not. You don’t lay that man down with a stair. You lay him down by undoing the betrayal.”

*

**

Magda said the obvious thing. A thousand years. Who could possibly answer for it. The kings and their armies were laid to rest and every child knows it.

“You’re right,” Thorne agreed. “There’s no company left and no descendants worth the name. If it wants the actual men, it’s impossible and we may as well go home.”

He held up a finger.

“But that’s not how a debt like that works. It’s been a thousand years — Thuban knows they’re dust. What holds him isn’t a grudge against nine specific bastards. It’s that **nobody ever came back for him**. He went over the side and the water closed and that was the end, and no company, no order, no god, no sister has stood over that water since and said *this was wrong, and he was ours, and we’re taking him home*.”

Gardwen spoke slowly, in the voice she used with her hands in the water.

“There’s a thing we do in the wood, for a beast that’s died badly. In a snare, or under a fall, where it couldn’t get free. You don’t pray it away. You go and you *sit* with it, and you say out loud that it wasn’t right, and then you carry it. That’s the whole rite. Somebody has to actually pick the thing up.”

She looked at Magda.

“It doesn’t need the ones who did it. It needs somebody willing to stand where they stood and answer for it. Not because it’s theirs. Because they’re the one who turned up.”

And Thorne said, quietly, laying a card down:

“And who exactly do we know that serves the god of the ones nobody sings about?”

He looked at her.

“Not the battle-dead, you said. The other kind. In the bed, in the byre, in the bad winter. A knight drowned in the dark by his own friends for refusing to burn a village, and left out of every song since, in every land, for a thousand years.”

A pause.

“Mother — whose *is* he, if he isn’t hers?”

Magda sat with that for a while.

“Fuck me,” she said. “Hel. The old lady has her ways.”

She put her cup down.

“All right. I’ll do it.”

CHAPTER 9 — THE MOUTH



Nobody paid for any of it with money.

Crowbill wanted the cargo. He was wiry and forgettable but for a small crow inked on the back of his right hand, and he ate bread and cheese off a paper while Magda talked and did not stop.

“Every day since it tied up. That’s not a boast, that’s my trade.” He wiped his fingers. “And here’s why it’s still sat there with everything on it. Ten men in scale and one way up. It’s a ship, so if it goes badly they don’t have to win, they just have to cast off. And a Baron. A man with a border tower and three hundred men and a long memory.”

He sat back.

“So tell me the two things I need. When is she sailing, and what do you want off her that isn’t cargo?”

“Tonight. And the knight who’s supposed to be competing in the tourney.”

He put the bread down and was quiet a long time, and then went and stood at the window that looked at a wall.

“I’ve a rule,” he said to the wall. “I’ve a few. Most of them are about money and one of them isn’t, and the one that isn’t is why I’ve still got a city to work in. Children aren’t stock. You don’t sell them, you don’t use them, and you don’t let anyone do it on my water and call it business.”

He came back but did not sit.

“Everything on that ship that isn’t the boy is mine. My name is nowhere. And when it’s done, the High Priestess of the Lake Lady stands up and says publicly that the canal folk kept her water clean. Not me. Not names. *The canal folk*. Because I’ve four hundred people who get moved on and blamed and dredged out of the channel, and one sentence from that woman is worth more to them than a Baron’s whole hold.”

Then, briskly: “And how do you propose we get past ten men in scale on a deck?”

“You’re the river men. I’m just a pig farmer.” Magda shrugged. “But she has to leave the pier to sail. Once she’s off it she’s not got four men at the bollards and four at a ramp. She’s a hull in the dark with a channel round her, and the channel’s yours.”

Crowbill’s face became interested.

*
**

Ravella’s price was two dead men.

She was half of one and half of the city’s, and she poured with faintly webbed fingers and did not hide them, and her eyes held the canal light a half-second too long.

“There are people living in the deep channels of this city who were here before the causeway. And for five days there has been a hot wound in the eastern channel that pushes ahead of the tide, and every one of them has had to move — old, young, sick. Two haven’t managed it.”

She turned her cup.

“And they came down our stairs. Four days ago. Three men with a lantern, digging out a door that has been shut and unmarked since before this city had a name. And they took things off it — the small confused ones that sit near the threshold and don’t go through, which are ours to look after and nobody else’s.”

“How many of the taken have you seen?”

“Two.”

“Then give them back. That’s the whole price.” She looked at Magda very directly. “You should understand what you’re agreeing to. There isn’t a version of this where a boatman walks home to his supper. He said yes to a warm coat in a cold winter and he has been paying for it ever since, and the kindest end available to him is the right one. You’d be taking him to that stair and standing there while it’s done.”

She turned the cup again.

“And I understand that’s your trade.”

*
**

The Mouth was a mile of slow black water where the harbour let out to sea.

Six punts, no lights, oars muffled in somebody’s shawl. Twelve canal men in dark wool, barefoot, each with a short blade and a coil of line and a grapnel wrapped in sacking so it could not ring. None of them asked what was on the ship.

Ravella sat in the bow of Magda’s punt with four of hers in the water alongside, invisible except that now and then the surface did something a surface should not.

A mile back, a lantern went up at the pier end and came down. Then another.

She came down the channel under a scrap of canvas and the sweeps, unlit but for one shaded lamp at the stern, and she was enormous close-to, and the hiss of her waterline carried flat across the surface.

“When I go in, that water will kill anyone who isn’t mine for about a minute while it turns,” Ravella said. “After that it’s cold and it’s climbable and I can hold it as long as I’m conscious. So say when, and be sure. I only get to do this once tonight.”

At eighty yards Magda said *now*.

*
**

The white line along the hull stopped. Forty feet of hissing steam ceased, mid-length, like a candle pinched out, and the slick behind it went dark and ordinary and cold.

Six punts moved at once. Grapnels landed with a sound like a fist in a pillow. Canal men went up the side of a moving ship barefoot with knives in their teeth.

But a ship that has hissed for five days and suddenly does not has changed its noise, and there was a man aft who had lived beside that sound long enough to notice its absence.

A voice on the quarterdeck. Then a shout. Then a bell.

*
**

Magda did not go up. She was seventy and in mail and could not swim, and what she was instead was a woman with a sling and a clear line at forty feet of rail with the sky behind it.

The first man leaned out with a knife for the grapnel lines and she put a stone past his head close enough to make him flinch, and that bought three seconds.

The second one took him under the raised arm where the scale gapes, side-on, and went in. He folded over the rail with his arms hanging and his legs still on the deck, which was worse for the men behind him than if he had gone into the water, because now the rail was blocked at exactly the place they were massing.

Then the bell stopped, and the shouting stopped, and it went very quiet up there very suddenly, which was the most frightening thing that had happened all night.

A lantern shutter opened on the quarterdeck and swung out over the side, and the cone of light came along the hull, punt by punt.

Looking for the boats.

He was a man who did not wear armour and had apparently never expected to need any. She put the stone through the middle of him before the light reached her, and she heard it hit at forty yards — the flat sound of a stone going into a body with nothing on it but wool. The lantern dropped out of a hand that had stopped working and hissed out in the water.

Somewhere up there a man said something short with no breath behind it.

*
**

She went up the rope on the second try and with the rage coming on, and came over the rail making a noise that stopped the fighting at the bow for a full second. It was not a war cry. It was the sound you make over a byre full of dead stock in a bad winter, and there were words in the middle of it about violators and stealers of souls and rapists of the dead, and every canal man on that deck decided at once that whatever it was, it was on their side.

Blau was on the quarterdeck steps on one knee with a hand pressed flat into his own middle, directing men who were peeling back from the bow to form on him.

“That’s her,” he said. “The northern woman.” A pause, and something that might have been a laugh with no air behind it. “Nobody told me she was *seventy*.”

He drew a working knife left-handed and could not make it work, because there was a hole in his abdomen and every time he bent at the waist something inside him refused. He came in short and slow and wide and had to put his other hand on the deck.

Neither of them touched the other. For a second they were a foot apart on a wet deck, both bleeding, both too old or too broken to finish it.

“Ah,” he said.

And he looked past her at the barred door under the quarterdeck.

“Cut the boy’s throat.”

The axe took him across the thigh and then, on the turn, into the hole she had already made from a rowing boat forty yards out. He went flat. There was a moment where he was looking at the mast, and then there was not anybody looking at anything.

Behind her, Gardwen's entangle came down the length of the deck and took the whole waist of the ship — cordage and weed and wet rope coming alive off the pins — and caught the knight at the door with the beam half out of its brackets.

*
**

The cabin was small and low and hot, and the air in it was scorched hair and something sweetish under it. Chalk on the boards, redrawn daily. A cot bolted down, stripped to the canvas because the sheets had gone ashore that morning in a laundress's bag.

The boy was seventeen and thin the way people are thin when someone else decides what they eat, and the whole upper left of his chest was a long-healed, re-opened, re-healed mess.

He looked straight at her, and there were two people looking out of his face.

"Don't—" said a boy's voice.

*"—**she's not here for you,**"* finished a voice a thousand years older.

Then, to Magda:

"Woman of the death-goddess. I have been listening to you come up this ship for a quarter of an hour, and I know who sent you, and I have been waiting for somebody to come with that particular smell on them for a very long time."

He got an elbow under himself.

"Get us off this ship before the other one comes back with my bones."

CHAPTER 10 — THE LATCH



The first rite failed.

They laid the two drowned men on the stone at the head of the swept stair and pulled the sheet back off their faces, because you do not say words over a covered face. Ellick Sarn, and the sandy one whose name nobody had asked.

Magda knelt on wet stone and said it.

Mother of the darkness. Take these drowned back to their rest. It's time they went home.

Nothing happened. The water stayed cold. The lamps went on burning. She waited, because she had stood at enough gravesides to know the words sometimes take a minute.

They did not.

Ravella crouched on the other side of the bodies and looked at her across them, and was not angry, which was worse.

“It’s not the words. The words were right. You said *take them*. You’re asking her to come and fetch. She won’t. She never does — that’s the entire nature of your goddess. She takes the ones nobody sings about, and she takes them when somebody finally *brings* them.”

She laid two fingers on Ellick’s forehead.

“Nobody has come back for these two either. Ellick’s wife thinks he ran off. So do the part that costs you. Not ask her to take them. **Give** them to her. Say whose they are and say what was done to them and say that somebody came back — and mean the last one, because you’re the somebody.”

*

**

Magda muttered that she was not a priest, and then did it anyway.

Oi. Listen up then.

She named them as what they were. Brothers, workers, toilers, men. She said the true thing about a life, which is that it is made of imperfect plans and a little hope and a little selfishness and probably a great deal of love, and that they had died here, in the water, the water that takes all things.

Then the part that cost.

But then these bastards brought you back. To haul, and work, and toil. Because it helped them.

So fuck ‘em.

She was shouting at a hole in the ground.

Come with me, brothers. Rage with me at the loss and the death — and then go back to the dark deep sea. Go to your rest. Go now, my brothers. Go.

*

**

The water did not part or glow.

It went warm. That was all. It came up the steps past her knees like a draught from an open door in a cold house, and every lamp on that island bent toward it at once.

And the two men on the stone let go. There was no light. There was a slackening — she had seen it four hundred times in byres and beds and would know it anywhere. Whatever had still been holding

the shape of Ellick Sarn's face stopped holding it, and what was left was a boatman who had died, and looked it, and looked finished.

Ravella had both hands flat on the stone and her head down and stayed like that a long time. When she got up her face was wet and it was not canal water.

"They're through. The Court has them."

She looked at Magda.

"Nobody has said whose anybody was down here in four hundred years."

*
**

The quiet one came in an hour later with one set of oars and no lantern, and landed exactly where Ellick had landed, and took three tries to get the thing out of the boat.

Oiled cloth, roped, five feet long. He carried it up the drowned street on his shoulder and set it down on the stone at the foot of the stair — gently, the way you set down someone sleeping — and stood there breathing.

Then he said, to nobody, and it carried beautifully across still water:

"Ellick. Get up here and help me with him."

Twelve Swords of the Lake came over the wall and he was face-down on the stone before the echo finished. He did not struggle and he did not shout. He turned his head sideways against the stone and looked at the lamps opening one by one, and at the priestess, and then at the oiled bundle eighteen inches from his face, which he had set down so carefully and was not going to be allowed to touch again.

He answered three questions and they were all the wrong ones. Yes, that was Thuban Eta in the cloth. Yes, the removal would work at this stair. No, he would not tell them how.

Then he settled his shoulders against the wall and stopped.

To Hesper, unprompted, almost kindly: “You’ll open him at the wrong point and put a thousand-year-old knight into a priestess. I’d rather like to see that.”

*
**

They cut the wire off the wrists.

Hesper undid the reliquary knots one at a time, naming each, and the oiled cloth came back on long bones brown with age, laid the way you lay a man — and around the wrists, corroded almost to nothing but still there after a thousand years, two turns of iron wire.

They had put him in the water tied and nobody had ever taken it off.

Nerissa cut it and dropped it in the water, and the temperature of the air on that stair changed.

*
**

Before that, Magda had gone to the boy and told him what she meant to do: strip the mail off and go at him bare-handed and beat the general out of him.

Thuban Eta said no.

“But I understand why you thought of it, and I would have taken that offer from you gladly, if it worked.” He shifted, and the boy’s ruined chest moved, and he winced on the boy’s behalf. “You would beat me out of a child. I do not feel your hands, woman. *He* does. They have been cutting him open every morning for ten years to do exactly what you described. If pain could shift me I would have been shifted four hundred times.”

He let that sit.

“They did not fasten me in with iron. They fastened me in with the night I died. Every hour I have spent in here I have spent back on that boat with my hands tied, going over the side, looking up at Corran and Vey and the rest of them not doing anything. That is the room I have been kept in.

“And I cannot leave it, because to leave it I have to accept that it happened and that nobody came, and I have not been able to accept that, because it is unbearable, and I have had a thousand years of finding it unbearable.”

He looked at her steadily.

“So you do not need to fight me out. You need to come and get me out of that water. Say it was wrong. Say whose I am. Say somebody came.

“And you must mean it, and I will know if you don’t, because I have had a very long time to learn what people mean.”

Then, quieter:

“Open my bones and open your door. And then stand where they stood, and do not look away when I go under, because they did.

“That is all it ever needed. It has only ever needed one person to turn up.”

*
**

So she said the name and told the tale and stood where his company had stood, and named the murder out loud in front of twelve Swords and a priestess and a mage and a druid and a wolf and a whole Court listening from underneath.

She put Vell’s axe in the bones’ hands, because his own had gone into the water with him and hers was better anyway.

It was the first telling he had ever had.

And it was not enough.

She felt it not land. It was like putting a shoulder to a door that turns out to be a wall. The water stayed cold. The lamps did not lean.

The boy started to shake and the old voice came out ragged for the first time.

“—I can’t reach it, woman, there’s something across—”

And against the wall the roped man began to laugh. Quiet, delighted, entirely genuine.

“Oh, that’s *good*. You’ve done all of it properly and you’ve done it beautifully and you have forgotten one thing. He isn’t only held by the bones.”

He tipped his head back, thoroughly enjoying himself.

“The Baron wears the rest of him around his neck. And the Baron is at the Governor’s table three miles from here, being toasted.”

*
**

Hesper had it a moment later.

“The bones are the primary anchor. They’re where the weight of him sits. But the locket is the working one — the piece they carry, the one the daily ritual runs through. It’s not a spare. It’s the *latch*. They cut a piece off him a century ago and put it in that locket, and every morning they use it to hold the seat shut.”

He looked up.

“The door is open. The bones are open. He is willing — you did that, and it worked, and I want you to hear that it worked. But there is a lock on this and it is around Hanzo di Teufel’s neck.”

“The Tourney is at noon,” Nerissa said.

*
**

Magda did not join the planning.

She stood at the edge of it with the axe hanging from one hand and watched the roped man, and he knew she was watching, and after a while he opened his eyes and looked back, and the two of them held that while the others worked out how to get into a Governor’s box.

Then she walked over and did it.

It took one.

She found a grain sack by the stair and tipped out what was in it and put the head in and knotted the top.

“Might come in handy,” she said, to nobody in particular.

Corvin walked twenty feet away and was sick against a wall. Hesper closed his eyes for a moment and then went back to the bones, and did not look at her again for some time. Ravella said quietly to one of hers: *not that one. He doesn't go down there.*

Gardwen did not ask why. She asked: “Was he still worth anything?”

*
**

Nerissa came and stood in front of her, and her voice did not rise, and every Sword on that island could hear her.

“He was bound. On my island, under my cordon, taken by my people who had orders to hold him. And he was the only living soul who knew where Bettan is. Fourteen years old. Cheerful. Cutting girls' hair at a school on the Northern Isles for people who fill them up.”

Her hands were shaking slightly and she did nothing to hide it.

“I gave you a reason to stop, once, and you took it. So I will not pretend I did not know what you were. But you have just taken that child away from me and I do not know how to get her back.”

Magda said the rot was in her city and it would not leave because she asked it nicely.

Nerissa did not soften.

“You've mistaken me. I did not object because it was unclean. I have buried men off the tide-flats with their throats opened by people I then had to bless at Solstice. I objected because you cut up the only map to a fourteen-year-old girl and then said *might come in handy*.

“That isn't purity, Magda. That's arithmetic.”

She went to the boats. At the last she turned.

“I will work with you until this is finished, and I will do it wholeheartedly, and I will not pretend at you afterwards. When the boy is out and the Baron is down, you and I are done, and you will not be welcome on Temple Isle.”

A beat.

“Sword-Captain Vell’s axe stays with you. She’d have wanted that and I’m not petty.”

CHAPTER 11 — THE TOURNEY



The dawn casting found three.

Nerissa went into the channel at the school's water-stair to her knees and Gardwen took her hand and put the other flat on the wall of the building, and it took about four seconds.

"There," she said. Then, immediately: "No. Wait—"

Her grip tightened hard enough to make the priestess wince.

"There's three."

Three wrongnesses in a refectory where forty girls were being counted and treating it as an outrage. Bettan, fourteen, cheerful. And two more who had gone quiet for a week sometime in the last month and come back lovely and started asking everyone about their families.

Nobody had noticed. Why would they. A homesick child getting happier is the thing you want to see.

"They weren't collecting vessels," Gardwen said, grey. "They've been *filling* them. Here. For a month. Four hundred yards from that stair."

Nerissa came up out of the water very slowly.

"Then how many have they done?"

*
**

Magda slept four hours in a cell under the temple and gave the mail and the axe back on the steps.

“I said keep it.”

“Aye. And it’s about four stone and I’m seventy. That’s a young woman’s kit.”

Nerissa carried the axe in personally, which is not a thing a High Priestess does for a piece of armoury.

*
**

The field was on the north ground of Temple Isle with water on three sides and six thousand people on it. Bunting. Bad wine. Fried fish, which did a great deal to improve Magda’s mood.

In the Governor’s box: Prince Emeric, twenty-four, flanked and managed by three older men. Two Guildmasters. And Baron Hanzo di Teufel in dragon-green with a cup in his hand, being toasted, waiting for the Single Combat to be called.

On a chain under the green, something small.

A serving girl at four feet over the better part of an hour brought back the shape of it: a flattened gold oval about the size of a thumbnail, worn under the shirt, the chain showing at the collar. And every quarter hour his hand went flat to his chest over it, briefly, the way a man checks a purse — and after he did it, he looked round.

She was caught on the fourth pour. He smiled at her and said, pleasantly, in front of two Guildmasters and a Prince: *you’ve very good hands, girl. Who do you serve?*

“He wasn’t angry,” she said afterwards, with her hands not steady. “That’s what’s wrong with it. He was *pleased*.”

*
**

Temerach Nebulo shot in the Archery and did not look at the Governor's box once, which was remarkable, because everyone else did.

Magda got to her inside the competitors' rope wearing a novice's vestment that Nerissa pinned at the throat with her own hands and her mouth in a line, and would not meet her eye while doing it.

"Don't," she said, stepping back.

"Wasn't going to say a word."

"You were *radiating*."

The Javelin was sitting on an upturned crate with her bow across her knees doing nothing at all, which turned out to be the whole of her preparation. Magda gave her four sentences.

She did not react the way people react. She filed it, and asked one question.

"Is Conall alive?"

"Who?"

That stopped her properly — the first thing all day that had.

"Conall Bjornlasch. Dark. Twenty-two. Rides with me. He's been in this city three days."

"Never heard the name in my life, lass."

"...Then you don't know. None of you know. You've spent three days pulling this apart and nobody has mentioned him once." She put it aside, visibly, the way she did everything, and looked past Magda at the canopy and the man in dragon-green. "Later. The locket first. Tell me what it looks like, and how close you need to be."

*
**

She won the Archery on the second pass.

The boats went across the gap between the islands at a walking pace with the targets standing on them and the field was allowed six

shafts. The Guild man ahead of her put in four and the crowd was very pleased with four.

She did not track. That was the thing you noticed from the rail — everyone else swung the bow with the boat, and she put the bow where the boat was going to be and waited, and the target arrived at the arrow.

Six shafts. Six hits. The last two into the same target inside a handspan while the boat was at its furthest and fastest.

The noise the ground made was not applause. It was the noise people make when they have been shown something.

The prize was a purse, a silver bracer, and access to the Governor's court.

Nerissa was three steps from the dais with the bracer in her hands when a man in Governor's livery came down and took it out of them. The chamberlain who had kept Lilura in an anteroom for four hours. He did it beautifully — a small bow, a murmured word about the Prince wishing to honour the champion personally — and it was protocol, and correct, and there was nothing the High Priestess of the Lake Lady could do about it in front of six thousand people.

She stood there with empty hands.

So the warning never reached the Javelin. But the box did.

*
**

A boy in a Chandler's apron carried a fitted wooden case up the enclosure steps, handed it to a steward, said *for the Baron di Teufel, paid delivery*, and was gone before anyone thought to ask anything.

The note inside was written by a woman who had learned late.

YOUR SHIP IS ON THE BOTTOM. YOUR MAN IS DEAD. I HAVE
YOUR CHAMPION AND HIS BONES. — THE PIG WOMAN

He slid the lid. He looked into the box for about two seconds. He slid the lid back.

He said something to the Guildmaster beside him and the Guildmaster laughed.

Then he set the case down, stood, made a small apologetic gesture to the Prince — *forgive me, a moment* — and stepped out of the back of the canopy with his cup still in his hand.

He did not hurry. He did not look round the ground once.

He was very, very good.

*
**

The water-stair behind the enclosure was twelve feet wide with a wall on one side and thirty-odd steps down to a landing where three boats were tied.

Magda got there first, because she was closer and he was being unhurried and correct.

He got three steps down before he registered an old woman in a novice's vestment standing against the wall with a loaded staff sling.

"Ah," he said. And then, with what sounded like genuine warmth: "*The pig woman.*"

He had not put the cup down.

"You've cost me a great deal in three days and I would very much like to know how you did the ship. I'll pay for that answer, and I pay well. Or we can do the other thing, and you should know before you choose that you are standing on wet stone at the bottom of a walled passage, which is a dreadful place to fight a man like me."

Behind him in the arch, unhurried, blocking it, Temerach Nebulo already had an arrow on the string.

*
**

Magda spat on the step between them.

“Hel’s waiting for you, Baron. Time you went down.”

He threw himself sideways and was quick for fifty and the stone found him anyway. It took him high in the chest and turned him completely round and the cup went out of his hand and shattered, and he came up on one elbow on wet stone with his court silk torn open.

He was not warm any more.

His hand came up — palm out, fingers spread — and the air in that passage went dry.

“My lord Baron,” Temerach said, from the top of the stair. “Put the hand down.” The bow was drawn to the ear and held. “You are under arrest by warrant of the Order of the Lake Lady for the profanation of the Tourney and the sacred channel. There are two Guildmasters and a Prince forty feet above us. I have been trying to say those words to you for four years.”

The hand did not go down.

Magda went down the three steps with the staff held short in both hands, the way a woman goes at a rat in a grain store, and brought the end of it onto his wrist.

There was a crack that was mostly the staff and partly not.

The hand shut. Whatever had been gathering in that passage came apart all at once with a sound like a held breath let go, and the temperature came back, and somewhere above them a gull started complaining again.

He cradled the arm against his chest and looked up at her with his hair come loose and fifty years of never once being touched undone on a service stair by an old woman with a stick.

“You *hag*—”

His good hand moved toward his own collar.

She slapped it out of the air like a wasp off a pie, took a fistful of green silk and collar and chain together, and put her face four inches from his.

She did not pull straight away. She held him there and let him get a proper look at what had been coming up the stair for him, which was not a knight and not a magistrate. It was an old woman who kept pigs, sent by a goddess he had never once thought about, wearing a vestment she had no right to, with fried fish on her breath.

Then she pulled.

The chain broke across the back of his neck and took skin, and it came away in her fist: gold, warm, the warmth of a thing that has been alive against a chest for a hundred years, and heavier than it had any business being.

Inside it, something moved.

Above them, six thousand people were being told that the di Teufel champion withdrew through injury, and there was a certain amount of booing.

CHAPTER 12 — SOMEBODY CAME



The tide was right. Nerissa looked at the channel coming down the temple stair and said *it's thin*, in the voice of a woman reporting a fact she wished she could not feel.

It took forty minutes to get everything to Lost Isle. The boy, carried, awake and frightened, with Gardwen's hand in his the whole way. Ruhi in the bottom of the boat. Hesper with a box inside a box. Nerissa, who had left her own Tourney running behind her without a backward glance. Twelve Swords. Ravella, and four of hers in the water alongside, which no boatman in that city had ever had happen to them.

The drowned street. The swept stair. The bones on the stone with the wire cut off the wrists and a borrowed axe laid across them.

Hesper opened the outer box and then, with a great deal of care, the inner one.

The thing inside it moved.

*
**

They put the boy down at the top of the stair and Gardwen held him, and Thuban Eta came up into his face for what everyone there understood was the last time.

He looked at the bones. Then at the locket. Then at Magda.

“You came back,” he said.

“Aye.”

“Then I am ready, and I have been ready for a thousand years, and I would like you to be quick — because he is very tired and I have taken enough of his life.”

*
**

She did it exactly as she had done it before, because it had been right before.

She said the name first, out loud, so everyone on that rock had to hear it. **Thuban Eta.**

She told the tale in a market-day voice — the valley he would not burn, the argument he won in front of men who killed him for it, the boat in the dark, the wire on the wrists, the water. She named the wrong so it was in the air where it could be heard: *this was murder, and it was cowardice, and no one ever answered for it.*

Then she went two steps down into the black water in a vestment she had no right to, up to her knees, and stood exactly where nine men had stood over a bound knight a thousand years before and done nothing.

She did not look away.

“You went in here and nobody came. I came. You’re not theirs and you’re not his and you were never Valhalla’s, because they cheated you of the death that buys it.

“You’re hers. You’ve always been hers. And she takes the ones nobody sings about — but only when somebody finally brings them.

“Mother of the darkness. This is Thuban Eta and I have brought him. He’s yours. Take him home.”

*
**

The locket opened on the stone by itself. Not dramatically. It came apart the way a shell does when whatever was holding it shut has stopped bothering.

And the water went warm.

It came up past her knees like a draught from an open door in a cold house, and every lamp on that island bent toward it at once, and under the surface something enormous and patient turned over and paid attention.

On the stone the boy arched once against Gardwen's arms and made a sound that was two voices and then one voice and then no voice at all.

Something went down that stair.

She did not see it. She felt it go past her in the water, unhurried, the way a big fish goes past your legs in a river. And there was one moment, exactly one, of being *looked at* by something that was grateful and was not going to say so, because it was a soldier.

Then it was gone. The bones settled very slightly, the way bones do.

The water was just water.

*
**

The boy was limp in his sister's arms with his eyes open. Breathing.

"...it's quiet," he said.

*
**

Magda came up out of the water and her legs did not work properly and she did not much care. She got to them on her knees on the wet stone and put her arms round both of them at once and held on.

Then she came apart.

It was the ugly kind, from the chest, the kind that hurts your throat. A great old woman in a stolen vestment on a rock in a drowned street with her face in a druid's hair and one hand knotted in a boy's shirt.

Gardwen had hold of her arm with her free hand and did not let go of it. The boy did not understand who she was at all. He put his head against her anyway, because she was warm and there was nothing left in him to do anything else with. Ruhi shoved her whole head under Magda's elbow and stayed there.

Nerissa turned her back — not away from her; she turned and faced the others and made them stop looking, which was the kindest thing she did all week.

Hesper sat down heavily on the step with the empty locket in his hands and stared at nothing.

Ravella crouched at the edge of the stair and said something down into the water that was not in any language anyone there knew, and something answered, and this time everybody heard it.

*
**

It took a while.

When Magda got her breath the light had moved on the water and the boy was asleep against Gardwen with his mouth open, and Gardwen had not moved a muscle in case it woke him.

She looked at Magda over the top of his head. Her face was wrecked and about ten years younger.

"Magda. I don't know his name." A pause. "He was seven. We called him Bird."

"Call him Bird then. It'd be a lot better than anything those bastards called him." Magda wiped her face with the back of her wrist. "And he'll pick his own when he's ready. That's how it works. You get given one, and then one day you take one. Nobody's given him anything since he was seven."

Gardwen nodded and did not trust herself to say anything, and put her cheek back down on the top of his head.

CHAPTER 13 — THE OYSTER



Nerissa proclaimed it from the temple steps at the close of the Tourney, in front of the Governor and every Guild in Purewater and six thousand people who had come for the Single Combat and got something considerably better.

She named the desecration. She named the arrest. She named the fouling of the sacred channel and the fact that she had rung the alarm and been told to stop, and she looked directly at the Prince's chamberlain while she said that part.

Then she said the sentence she owed.

“The canal folk kept the Lady's water clean.”

She said it slowly and let it sit. When the ground did not know what to do with it she said it again, louder, and added *say it back to me* — and six thousand people did.

Somewhere on the water a very forgettable man with a crow inked on his hand heard the whole city say it.

*
**

Temerach told Conall in a small room off the south cloister, standing with her hands at her sides like a woman giving a report, because it was the only register she had and it turned out to be the right one.

Four things, and then he could do whatever he liked to her. That the Baron was his father. That he had a twin brother somewhere in the city. That she had known both since before she took him in at nineteen and had chosen every day not to tell him. And that the man was arrested and would say it all out loud in front of a magistrate tonight to buy himself an hour, so he was going to hear it today whatever she did.

“I wanted it to be from me. That is not the same as it being right.”

He was quick, so he did not get the easy reaction. He went straight past *you’re lying* and landed on all the small things at once.

That’s why you found me at nineteen. That’s why we came to Purewater.

He looked at the stranger in the room, the one with no stake.

“Is she telling the truth?”

Magda pulled the vestment off over her head and dropped it on a chair, which answered the question of who was talking before she opened her mouth.

“Yeah. Course she is.”

She did not dress it and did not tell him it would be all right.

“Go find your brother.”

*
**

Marisette found him inside the hour, because Marisette had known the boy since he was four.

They picked the Moist Oyster because Thorne was owed the true version, once, and because it was the only room in Purewater where a Guildmaster, a thief, a priestess and a wolf could all be in the same place and nobody would comment.

Constantine sent food she could not afford to send. Marisette sent wine nobody would be able to afford again. Ravella came in through the water-door with four of hers, which stopped the room for a

moment. Ila was there because she had threatened Constantine with a very specific kind of hell, and had attached herself to Bird — who sat in the warmest corner in three cloaks, eating steadily, saying almost nothing, with Gardwen on one side and a wolf across his feet.

Nerissa did not come. She sent Lilura, and a note, and a cask.

Hesper came late from the school and said the two shallow girls were out and sleeping, and did not say anything about the third.

And Thorne sat in his corner with his chalk, watching the door.

At about the ninth bell Asphodel came in with a young man behind her. Dark. Twenty-two. Well-dressed in a way that was not his money.

He was halfway through saying something to her when he saw the man standing up at the far table with his own face on him, and the sentence stopped.

The whole room stopped with it.

Neither of them said anything.

And Thorne said, very quietly, to nobody at all:

“Oh, that’s good.”

CHAPTER 14 — WHAT IS STILL OPEN



Four days.

An old woman came down out of the north on eleven nights of the same dream and walked into a city she half remembered. She swore herself to a stranger at a ford. She killed a Baron's heir with a stone and fed him to hogs. She took a ship in the Mouth, killed the man who ran it, and tore a hundred-year-old latch off a nobleman's throat on a service stair while six thousand people booed a champion who was never going to come.

And she stood in black water and gave a murdered knight back to the goddess who takes the ones nobody sings about, because it turned out that all it had ever needed was one person to turn up.

That is what closed.

Here is what did not.

*
**

Bettan is still in a room on the Northern Isles. Fourteen, cheerful, and carrying something that came off a threshold under a drowned island. Two of the three girls came out and are sleeping. Hesper has not said anything about the third, and Magda destroyed the only living map to how any of it was done, because a man was pleasing himself and she had an axe.

Nerissa said what that was and she was right, and she said it in front of twelve Swords, and she will not take it back. She will also not be welcoming Magda on Temple Isle again. Both of those things are true and neither cancels the other.

Emmeralda is still in the green room. Comfortable, charming, asking after people by name and requesting her shawl. What is seated in her likes the house and likes being fussed over and has spent thirty hours learning how Hesper's mind works. Nobody has any idea how to get it out, and the man who might have known is in a sack.

The Awake the Dragon Movement lost a candidate, not a purpose. They funded Hanzo. They kept the texts and the money and the patience, and they still hold his border tower — a hundred years of that family's work sitting empty tonight with nobody in it. A courier came down the sea road for that ship two nights ago. Somebody will read what came back.

And there are two young men standing in a tavern looking at each other.

Bastards do not inherit. But Santo di Teufel is dead and Hanzo will be attainted, and when a Crown disposes of a border march it looks for blood because it is tidier than a garrison. There are men in three counties who will hear *the di Teufel bastard* and start doing arithmetic.

Neither of them has any protection at all except an elven knight who lied to one of them for three years, and an Order that owes them nothing.

*
**

And there is a stair.

It is uncovered now, and swept, and the weed has been cut back off the treads, and everyone who put it there is dead or roped or gone.

It goes down into water that does not hold lamplight. It is a door for the drowned, older than the Lake Lady's presence in that channel, in no doctrine the High Priestess has read in forty years.

The Mermaid's Court has been keeping the small confused things near its threshold since before the causeway, and three men with a lantern came down and took two of them and nobody could stop it.

Somebody has now opened that door twice in one night and it worked both times.

Thorne is still owed the true version. All of it, in order, told once and never written down.

He is going to want it soon.